wanted him to go but, once we were into the week-in, week-out business of training and playing games, the idea of May coming and the boss packing it in didn't really affect us. We definitely couldn't use it as an excuse for losing games. My only concern was about who'd be replacing him. I was sorting out a new contract at United and I was worried that my relationship with a new manager might not be as good as the one I'd always had with the boss. For all that I'd been a United supporter, Alex Ferguson was one of the main reasons I'd left London and signed for the club when I was a boy. Even so, any doubts about the future didn't get in the way of playing for United in the here and now.

If the team was unsettled, it probably had more to do with having lost Steve McClaren over the summer. I've already said how highly I rate Steve as a coach. In June 2001 he left United to become manager at Middlesbrough. With the boss expected to leave, I don't think it was a case of Steve wanting any kind of guarantee that he'd replace him. He just wanted to know he'd be considered. I think there were meetings behind the scenes and it became pretty clear that United didn't see him as the future number one. So, when Steve was offered the 'Boro job, nobody was surprised he took it. And all of us, including the manager, wished him well. During that season, the boss stepped in to take training from day to day: he's a decent coach as well as everything else. Never mind winding down for retirement, the boss was more involved than ever in 2001/02. Steve was a big loss, though: sessions with him were really enjoyable and, technically, right up to the minute.

He knows how to communicate information to players better than anybody I've ever worked with. In his couple of years with us, he'd made his mark at Old Trafford just like he had in the England set-up.

Of course, I still had the chance to work with Steve on international duty, as he stayed on with England, while he was managing 'Boro, until after the 2002 World Cup. We'd been together again for the game against Germany in Munich. And, four days after that, we were up at St James' Park for Albania. Steve talked about lifting ourselves for it. So did Sven. The Wednesday night after the Saturday afternoon was the time to make the 5–1 result count: another three points for the taking. But being ready for it didn't make any difference. Albania at home turned out to be a much harder game. The players were tired. There was expectation in the air again, especially after what had happened in Munich. People thought that, if we could beat Germany 5–1 away, we could beat anybody. Well, we beat Albania but it was close and it wasn't a performance to remember. They were already out of the World Cup and had nothing to lose. They got plenty of players back in defense and hoped